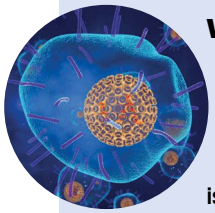
ALL ABOUT SHINGLES

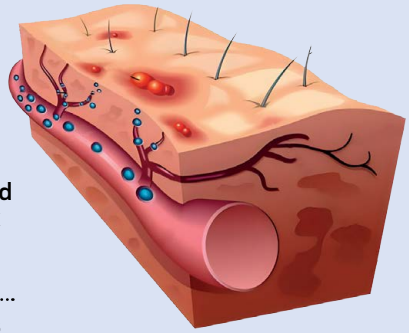


WHAT IS SHINGLES?

- A viral infection, shingles or herpes zoster is caused by the varicella-zoster virus, which also causes chickenpox
- It belongs to the group of herpes viruses, but is not the same as those causing cold sores or genital herpes

HOW DO YOU GET IT?

- Only someone who has had chickenpox can get shingles
- The virus stays dormant, near nerve clusters in the spine or cranium
- When immunity reduces with age or due to any illness or certain medical treatments, it reactivates



WHAT ARE THE SYMPTOMS?

- It happens in three phases, starting with shooting pain in the skin with likely fatigue
- In the second phase, small bumps appear on one side of the body, which turn into pus-filled blisters, along with high fever. At this stage, the disease is self-limiting, and the blisters crust over in 7-10 days
- The third phase happens to those with a weakened immunity, after about 3-4 months. There is a blinding pain in the skin that can last up to a year. The treatment is only symptomatic

IS THERE A VACCINE?

- Yes. Launched in India in April, Shingrix is available for Rs 7,500-10,999 per dose
- It protects against the disease, and reduces its severity in those few cases where protection fails



- It is a non-live vaccine with no major side-effects; recommended for those above 50 (or above 19 in case of weak immunity)
- It is given intramuscularly in two doses spaced over two to six months

how little people know about the disease—a fact established by a 2023 study conducted by the Association of Physicians of India (API) in collaboration with the market research firm Ipsos. While 72 per cent of the 216 shingles patients aged 50 and above surveyed across 16 cities were unaware of the viral disease before they got it, 73 per cent didn't know that they could get it again.

For treatment to be effective, it must be started within 72 hours of the onset of symptoms. "But because of the myths and misconceptions around shingles, it usually begins late, leading to a decrease in its efficacy," says Dr Rashmi Hegde, medical affairs director, GlaxoSmithKline. According to the API-Ipsos survey, only 19 per cent of the patients visited the doctor immediately after they developed symptoms. The average time patients take to consult a doctor was 12-14 days after the onset of the symptoms. Reason: shingles patients find it difficult to differentiate between it and other skin conditions. "Some believe that shingles is just a regular rash due to an allergen," says Dr Hegde. "Or that it can be treated at home."



"PAIN DUE TO SHINGLES CAN BE AS SEVERE AS LABOUR PAIN OR POST-SURGICAL PAIN. IN SOME CASES, IT CAN LAST FOR MONTHS OR YEARS AFTER THE RASH HAS SETTLED"

–DR RASHMI HEGDE
Medical Affairs Director, GlaxoSmithKline

How can you tell that you may have shingles? The disease develops in three stages. The first manifests in the form of intense pain erupting in the skin, even before the rash appears, at times accompanied by fatigue. In case it occurs on the abdomen, people tend to mistake it for a heart or stomach issue.

The second stage is when the rash appears, usually in a specific area on one side of the body, unlike chicken pox that covers the whole body. It starts as a cluster of small bumps—red, pink, grey, purple or brown, depending on the skin tone—which turn into pus-filled blisters. It is accompanied by a high fever that lasts a few days as the body battles the infection. "The virus usually lies dormant in a part of the body where nerves gather around your spine or cranium," explains Dr Sheela